

ments, photos, exported projects, and anything else that would hurt to lose. Microsoft's File History documentation is still very straightforward: connect an external drive or choose a network location, then turn on File History from Control Panel under System and Security.

Step-by-step: set up a second local backup with File History

1. Connect an external hard drive or SSD to your Windows PC.
2. Open Control Panel.
3. Go to System and Security.
4. Click Save backup copies of your files with File History.
5. Choose the connected drive and turn File History on.
6. Let Windows begin backing up eligible files. Microsoft says File History is designed to save backup copies of your files to the selected drive or network location.

This is not old-fashioned paranoia. It is what separates "my files are synced" from "my files still exist even if something goes badly wrong."

Protect your most sensitive files differently

Some files are not merely important. They are dangerous to lose or expose. Passport scans, PAN and Aadhaar copies, tax records, legal documents, contracts, insurance paperwork, recovery key records, and family financial documents deserve more than just casual placement in a general cloud folder. This is where Microsoft's OneDrive Personal Vault becomes useful. Microsoft says Personal Vault adds an extra layer of security using additional authentication, and that Microsoft 365 Basic, Personal and Family subscribers can store as many files in it as their storage limit allows. Microsoft also notes that Personal Vault automatically relocks after inactivity.

Step-by-step: use Personal Vault for sensitive files

1. Open OneDrive.
2. Locate or set up Personal Vault.
3. Authenticate with the extra verification step.
4. Move your most sensitive files into it.
5. Keep only the truly critical documents there, rather than dumping your entire digital attic into a high-security drawer. Microsoft says Personal Vault is best suited to your most important files and uses an added layer of identity verification.

This is especially useful for households where several people share a device but not the same threshold for digital chaos.

Test your restore path before a real disaster

This is where many backup strategies collapse into vibes.

WINDOWS BACKUP SETUP FOR MOST READERS

For a typical home or office user in India, this is the practical sweet spot:

- Windows Backup turned on for settings, apps, credentials and preferences.
- OneDrive folder backup enabled for Desktop, Documents and Pictures.
- Sensitive records placed in Personal Vault.
- A second local copy of truly important data on an external drive, ideally through File History or regular manual copies.
- Occasional checks that files are syncing and restorable.

That is not overkill. That is just a grown-up Windows setup.

And it matters more than ever now that Windows 10 support has ended as of October 14, 2025, with Microsoft urging users toward Windows 11 for ongoing support and security updates. If you are upgrading devices, refreshing old machines, or moving into a newer Windows workflow, having a proper backup-and-restore routine is not just convenient. It is part of the transition itself.

Microsoft's Windows Backup guidance is clear about backup and restore being paired ideas. Microsoft also documents recovery tools such as System Restore, Reset this PC, recovery drives, and other Windows recovery options. Translation: backup is only half the story; recovery is the real exam.

Step-by-step: test whether your Windows backup is actually useful

1. Open OneDrive on the web and verify your key folders are visible there.
2. Open a few files from Desktop, Documents, and Pictures to confirm sync integrity.
3. Check Windows backup settings again and verify the categories you care about are enabled.
4. Restore one deleted test file from OneDrive to understand the recovery path. Microsoft documents deleted-file recovery in OneDrive, including recycle-bin behaviour.
5. If using File History, open the external drive backup and verify files are really there.

A tested backup feels different from a theoretical one. It replaces anxiety with boring confidence, which is exactly what backup should do. 